

Do We Really Need Anonymous Evaluations?

An Ethical Analysis of Student Evaluations of Course & Teaching (SECT)

PRESENTERS

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Context & The HCMUS Reality

Has anyone ever shared what they **truly think** in course evaluations?

In education, students feel less safe when their anonymity is not protected.
(Sullivan et al., 2024)

Tư duy tính toán (24A02)

☐ Đánh giá chung về môn học và giảng viên:

☒ Nếu anh/chị muốn có ý kiến chi tiết về từng tiêu chí, vui lòng trả lời bên dưới

1. Về sự minh bạch thông tin liên quan đến môn học (đề cương, mục tiêu, chuẩn đầu ra, phương pháp đánh giá)

☒ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

2. Về tải trọng học tập của môn học

☒ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

3. Về kiến thức được truyền tải trong môn học

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☒ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

4. Về năng lực tự chủ và trách nhiệm được rèn luyện qua môn học

☐ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☒ 4 ☐ 5

5. Về trình tự sắp xếp môn học trong chương trình đào tạo

☒ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

6. Về sự phù hợp của tài liệu học tập so với đề cương môn học

☒ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

7. Về phương pháp giảng dạy của giảng viên

☐ 1 ☒ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

8. Về nội dung truyền tải của giảng viên so với đề cương môn học

☒ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

9. Về tiêu chí và phương thức đánh giá điểm quá trình của giảng viên

☒ 1 ☐ 2 ☐ 3 ☐ 4 ☐ 5

CÂU HỎI MỞ: Những điều hài lòng hoặc chưa hài lòng về môn học và giảng viên

Ý kiến của bạn...

Anonymity Concerns

Login process

We must log in with personal accounts, raising concerns about anonymity



Transparency

Evaluators are unsure who will see their feedback.

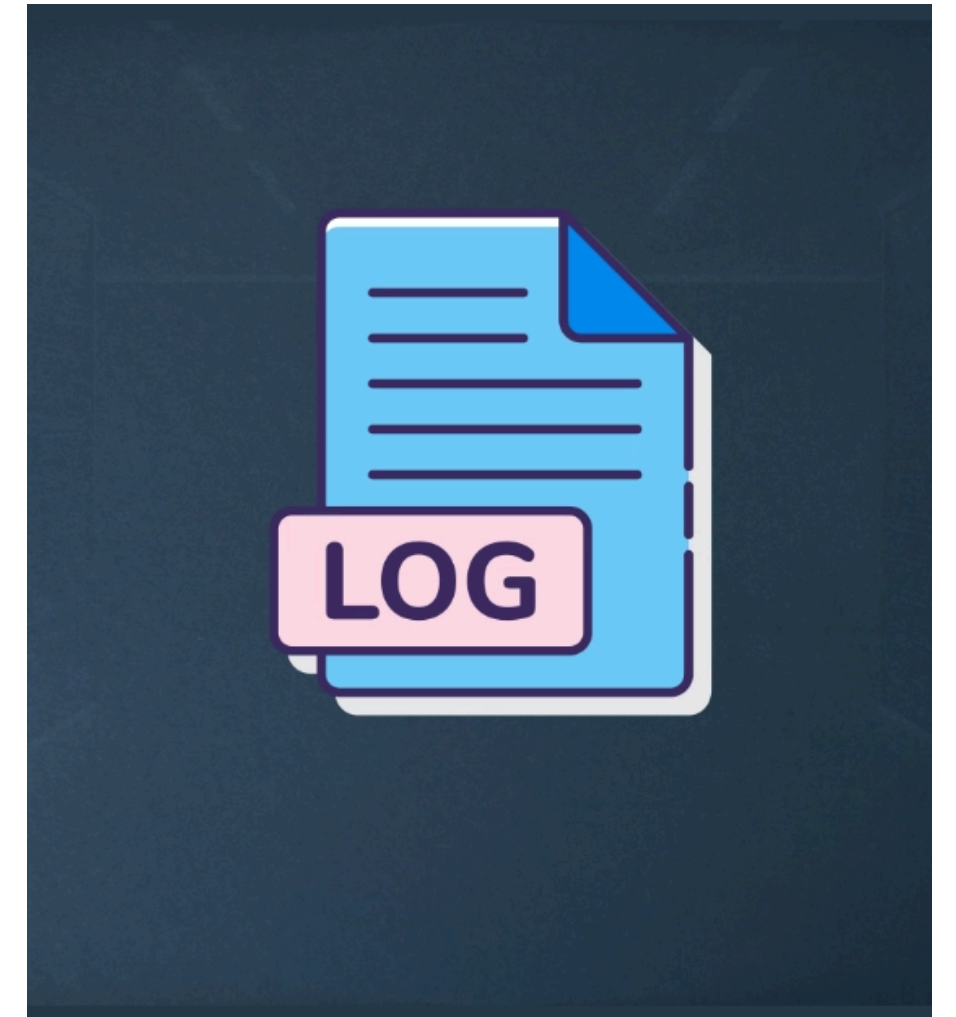


Writing style

The writing style itself may reveal the evaluator's identity.

Is “Anonymous” Really Anonymous?

- Would evaluators truly be anonymous if they didn't provide their personal information? Unfortunately, not necessarily.
- The system may still collect:
 - Login information
 - Timestamps, IP addresses
 - Device or system logs
- The instructors may not know the student's identity, but the **third-party operator might**.
- Therefore, anonymity still requires **trust in the system and its administrators**.



Anonymous or Confidential?



Why anonymity matters

Institutional Imbalance

Instructors have significant power over students' grades, recommendations, research opportunities, and academic standing.

- Students may be vulnerable to inappropriate or abusive behaviour and may be reluctant to report it when their identity is exposed.
- Students may fear retaliation, damaged relationships, fewer academic opportunities, or unfavourable treatment in future courses.

Why anonymity matters

Protection

Anonymity can make students feel safer, encouraging more honest feedback. **Constructive feedback** may subsequently contribute to improvements in teaching quality.

A study comparing medical residents' evaluations on 51 faculty members produced the following results:

- Anonymous evaluations gave lower scores for **48/51** faculty members with an average score of **5.4**
- For non-anonymous evaluations: average score is **6.1**

Faculty Evaluations by Medicine Residents Using Known versus Anonymous Systems

Dayton W Daberkow 2nd ¹, Charles Hilton ¹, Charles V Sanders ¹, Sheila W Chauvin ¹

Affiliations + expand

PMID: 28253140 DOI: [10.3402/meo.v10i.4380](https://doi.org/10.3402/meo.v10i.4380) 

[Free article](#)

Abstract

Purpose: This study examined the extent to which faculty evaluation results differed, based on whether residents were required to submit ratings anonymously or not.

Method: We used a retrospective analysis of existing records representing Internal Medicine residents' evaluation of 51 faculty members in an anonymous and known (non-anonymous) rater system on an inpatient medicine service.

Results: Mean scores for 48 of 51 individuals were lower for anonymous than non-anonymous evaluations. The mean scores were as follows: Anonymous = 5.4 (95 % CI, 5.2-5.6); Nonanonymous = 6.1 (95 % CI, 5.9-6.3). Regression analysis of mean scores for non-anonymous evaluations against those for anonymous evaluations revealed a significant relationship ($r = 0.83$, $p < 0.001$).

Conclusions: Faculty evaluations completed anonymously by residents are significantly lower than those for which resident identities were known. Given the strong, significant relationship between individual faculty members' evaluation ratings from both systems, other factors influencing evaluations should be considered. No subgroups suffered more under anonymous rankings.

Anonymity protects honesty, but may also reduce accountability.

If Truly Anonymous, What Goes Wrong?

Dissociation & Reduced Accountability

Anonymity can weaken social and moral restraints.
Suler (2004) — Online Disinhibition Effect

Toxic & Non-Constructive Feedback

Studies of anonymous student evaluations found insults, personal attacks, and non-constructive comments.
Lakeman et al. (2022)

Trolling & Deliberate Harm

An experiment with 242 university students found that participants engaged in more trolling behavior under anonymous conditions.
Nitschinsk, Tobin & Vanman (2022)



Empirical Bias & Validity Deficits

23,000+

Evaluations Analyzed by Boring, Ottoboni, & Stark (2016)

Their findings suggest that SECT scores may reflect instructor gender and other demographic factors more strongly than actual learning outcomes.

Grading Leniency Bias

SECT scores often reflect expected grades, not teaching quality

Demographic & Gender Penalties

Ratings can vary based on instructor gender and demographics.

Absence of Due Process

Faculty cannot easily challenge false or abusive evaluations.

Ethical Analysis I — Utilitarianism

LECTURE NOTE LN02

Act Utilitarianism

- **Benefit:** Supports anonymity because it yields immediate, uninhibited student feedback, improving education quality
- **Harm:** Psychological harm, faculty burnout, and reputational damage caused by toxic evaluations.

LECTURE NOTE LN02

Rule Utilitarianism

- Adopting "*absolute, unmoderated anonymity*" degrades academic morale, incentivizes grade inflation, and erodes trust.
- **Conclusion:** Unrestricted anonymity fails to maximize long-term social utility.

Its moral acceptability therefore depends on whether the educational benefits outweigh the resulting harm.

Ethical Analysis II — Kantian Deontology



Universal Law

Spiteful, unverified anonymous feedback cannot be universalized without undermining the credibility of feedback systems.



Ends vs Means

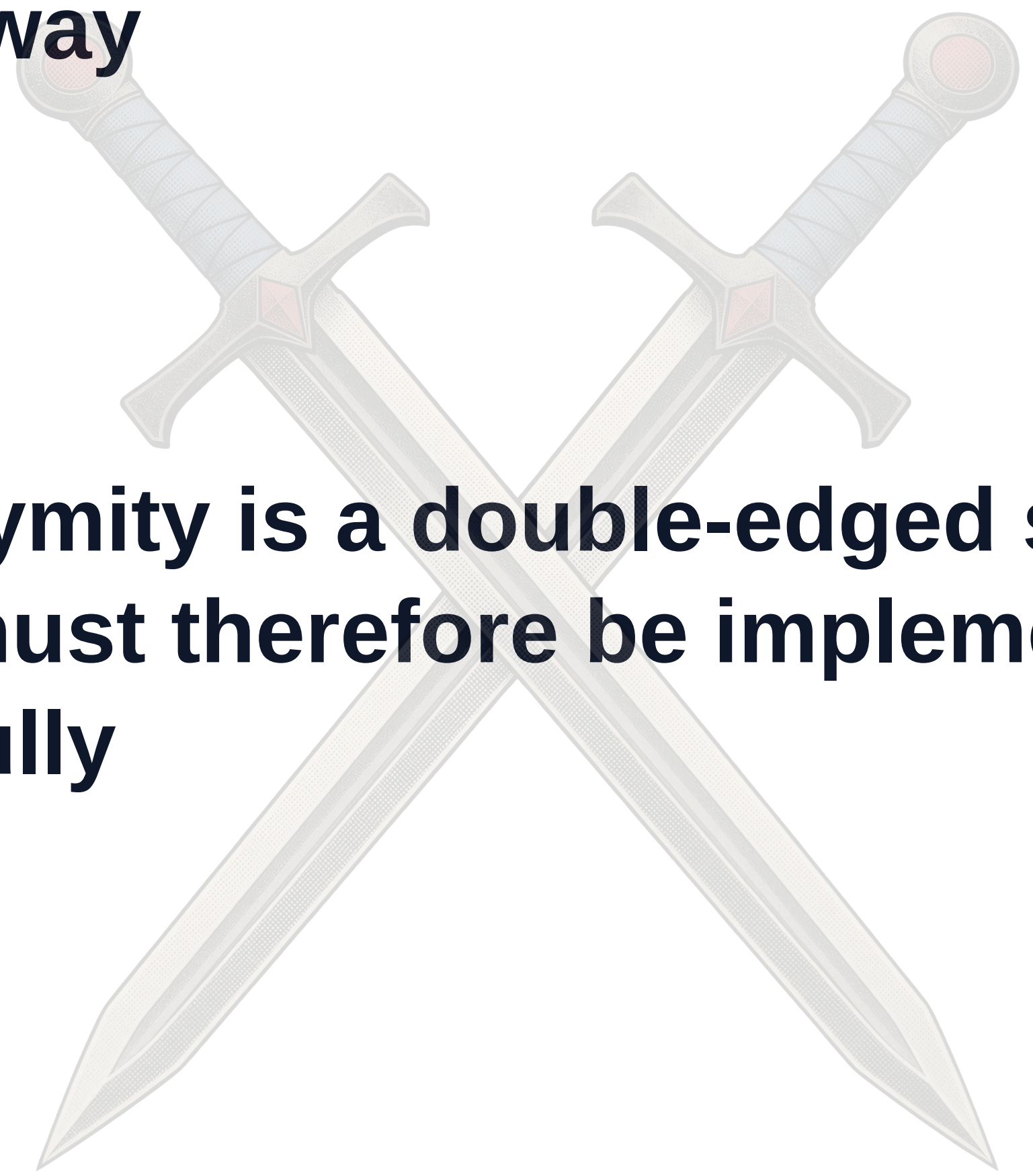
Using anonymity to vent personal anger treats instructors merely as a means to an emotional end, violating human dignity.



Duty of Constructiveness

Moral agents have a duty to provide truthful, respectful, and constructive feedback, not abusive comments.

Key Takeaway



**Anonymity is a double-edged sword
and must therefore be implemented
carefully**

Solutions

From the university's perspective, the system can be implemented in a way that protects students' anonymity while maintaining accountability.

LAYER 01

**SSO
Authentication**

LAYER 02

**Cryptographic De-
ID**

LAYER 03

**Real-Time NLP
Screening**

LAYER 04

Emergency Escrow

Students' Responsibilities

As students, we have our own responsibilities:

Objectivity

Evaluate courses based on **teaching quality** and **course content**, not grades, emotions, or personal feelings toward instructors.

Language

Avoid insults, hate speech, and personal attacks. Anonymity should not be used as a shield for abusive language.

Constructiveness

Explain the reasons for criticism and suggest possible improvements rather than simply complaining.

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